

Session 17 DM Guide

Revised September 29, 2026 after Scott's causal-chain decisions. This is unplayed preparation; the Word/PDF copies are rebuilt from this guide. DM background is distinct from player knowledge and from future outcomes.

The missed delivery and the council map

Run a substantial investigation that earns the party a voice in Greenest's defense. Start at the chalk cut, reveal an imminent threat to Greenest, offer investigation of the camp, then use earned evidence to let the players plan a response. Stop before resolving that operation.

Four arcs with a decision ending

Arc 1 • Missed delivery • 20-25 minutes. Mara, Doss, the plate, evidence of imminent mill work and a reason to investigate the camp.

Arc 2 • A playable camp • 35-45 minutes. Scout, enter, make contacts and manage suspicion.

Arc 3 • Evidence and the map puzzle • 35-45 minutes. Reconstruct three coordinated enemy assignments from three clues.

Arc 4 • Earn trust and give orders • 40-50 minutes. Return by their chosen route, present evidence, debate deployments and record orders.

Allow 15-20 minutes for recap and a break: roughly 2½-3 hours. These are pacing estimates, never reasons to delay a solved scene. If camp play expands, finish the council at the start of next session rather than skipping player choices.

Opening and continuity

Dawn, north-road chalk cut; Throk holds the dark stone control plate with gold/brass inlay. The paper says before dawn. No automatic rest, refill, level-up or hallucination penalty. Confirm resources at the table; all five remain level 2. The mill rescue succeeded, the old arch stays sealed, and the plate test revealed a physically broken channel.

What is new in this revision

The two-objective raid, Plan B and independent dragon interest are approved DM background in 01/03/05. NPC encounters, discovery sequence, timing, evidence acquisition, council allocations and outcomes remain unplayed prep. Nighthill's willingness to delegate and Escobert's respect for expertise do not erase the party's reputation. Earn confidence through evidence and a workable plan.

DM truth and what the players know

The first mill team had two jobs: open the old arch and recover whatever lies behind it, and recover the intact control plate. The damaged mechanism would not open. They pried out the portable plate and withdrew; the party intercepted them before delivery. Floyd missed no enormous hidden machine. The arch, its visible damaged channels and adjacent masonry explain everything needed here.

Failure triggers Plan B: Wheel draws defenders north, Lantern observes and signals, and Spade enters beneath the mill and breaks through masonry beside the sealed arch to recover the contents. Spade needs no plate. Its mission is retrieval, not destruction of the mill or ancient mechanism. Excavation can endanger supports, but that is a risk of its method, not its objective. Do not define the contents yet.

The plate is independently valuable. Its interrupted route is mill raiders > chalk-cut couriers > further north > eventual intended recipient/network. Frulam Mondath directs the raiders and is connected to the Cult of the Dragon. Lennithon independently wants both the plate and the contents. Their interests overlap without making him her boss. Do not explain his reasons, identify the flyover dragon to the players, or equate him with the unresolved Stormwreck omen.

At opening the PCs know only their discoveries and the delivery lead: the plate fits; the amber pulse stopped at the existing physical break; the arch did not open; they removed it; Throk has it; they chose the chalk cut at dawn. They do not know Frulam or Lennithon, Wheel/Lantern/Spade, the full operation, the contents, a dragon's motive or that a larger camp necessarily exists. A DM paragraph is not a read-aloud.

Hoard of the Dragon Queen and Tyranny supply selected people, places and Cult material. The arch, plate mystery and Wheel/Lantern/Spade operation are campaign customizations. No published sequence or Tiamat endgame is required, and no Forgotten Realms lore is needed to solve this session.

Prepare these materials

Show the existing chalk-cut intro and tactical map. Keep the existing payment slip concealed until earned.

Use S17_04_Camp_Labeled.png for camp navigation. Use S17_06_Strategy_Map.png for the shared council map and give Sev S17_06_Sev_Only.png privately when the party obtains or copies the survey map.

Reveal the roadside papers first, then cut or separately reveal the three camp clue cards. The DM solution and council record stay private.

Guardrails

No forced plate surrender, camp assault, civilian evacuation or military appointment. No identity answer for the dragon, departure omen, Pat's ancestry or Floyd's divine source. The dragon flyover is a brief mid-session event; it never ends the adventure by itself.

Current main-branch sources: 00, CHATGPT_PROJECT_INSTRUCTIONS, 01, 02, 03, 04, 07, 09, 10 and 11 in sstudham/dnd-campaign. Revision follows Scott's direction to make the camp playable and end with strategic decisions.

Arc 1 The missed delivery

Start on the road at the chalk cut • Do not begin in town

Opening read aloud

Dawn turns the chalk walls white. Fresh wagon tracks lead around the bend. Someone shouts, "Stop pulling. You're making it worse." A half-loaded mule cart stands beside a fresh collapse. One young man is pinned beneath stone and broken timber. A woman turns toward your footsteps. "You're late."

Run the meeting

If Throk displays the plate, Mara recognizes it and addresses him. If it is wrapped or concealed, she asks whether they brought the delivery; do not give her supernatural recognition. The intro art illustrates possible visibility, not a decision imposed on the player.

Mara Venn is a paid intermediary for Frulam Mondath's network. She wants the plate intact, Doss alive and her route protected. Doss Fen is hired labor, not a fanatic. The single guard prioritizes Doss. A messenger has already ridden north because the delivery missed its deadline.

Keep the rescue short. Floyd freely recognizes that the upper chalk must be braced or pressure relieved beside Doss's leg. A credible careful solution works. Use DC 9 with help or DC 11 for rushed uncertain execution; a setback costs time, cart load or minor injury, not an arbitrary death. Do not repeat the full mill rescue.

After help, Mara says: "You could have left him. I noticed. Now tell me whether we are doing business."

Information that opens the adventure

The payment slip shows organized northward transfer, but that alone is not the reason to enter a camp. Add the road dispatch: failed opening at the mill, tools due at a northern camp by midday, new work at Greenest at dusk, and the plate moving separately. Doss can say, "They want the tools back for another job at the mill tonight." Mara can explain, "I

handle this transfer. The survey desk up north issues the work routes.” Neither names Frulam, Lennithon or a dragon as the buyer.

Offer the actual question: what are they planning at Greenest, and how can it be stopped? The camp coordinates tools, routes and signals, so its papers or workers can answer it. The party can investigate, watch, send a scout or return with the warning already earned. They do not need to agree to infiltration for the story to continue.

Mara knows the next transfer point, payment and hauling schedules, not the sealed contents or final recipient. The initials F.M. and L. remain unresolved. The messenger departed before meeting the PCs and knows only of the missed delivery; he cannot already have reported their identities or plate custody.

Let their approach create access

Help and bargain: Mara can provide a route or introduce them as contractors with a paperwork dispute. If she knows they carry the plate, agree explicitly whether she conceals that fact; she may bargain for Doss’s care or her safe withdrawal and still protect herself later. Bluff: the work order and a plausible answer to “Who told you not to turn the channels?” support a courier cover. Observe or refuse: rider tracks, wagon tracks, Doss or the route sketch provide an independent way north. No exact password and no clue gated behind one roll.

Keeping the plate is valid. Conceal it before ordinary camp infiltration. An openly declared delivery is a negotiation with people who want the object, not a free pass to wander. Surrendering it is also valid; honor the 40 gp payment if they pass as couriers and track its custody. Following a cart must not become an offscreen theft.

If they choose violence or withdrawal

Only Mara and the guard fight; Doss does not. Reuse S16 Hired Raider: AC 12, HP 9, speed 30, club +3, 1d4+1. They surrender or withdraw. Captured papers or survivors retain the camp lead. Do not add a surprise wave.

If they withdraw toward town, honor it. The work order and witness can still prompt reconnaissance; a willing local scout can bring incomplete camp evidence. Do not move the whole camp encounter onto the road or pretend they visited it.

Transition

Beyond the chalk hills, cooking smoke hangs low over a shallow valley. Wagons stand among tents. Some people carry weapons; others carry tools. This is where the work was organized. You have time to watch before deciding how to enter.

Arc 2 The camp is a place to play

Use the camp map • Offer visible routes before asking for checks

Six connected locations

A Delivery entrance: a clerk asks who sent them and what they carry. A work order, Mara’s introduction or a credible cover opens conversation. Concealed custody is not magically detected. If the plate is shown or credibly reported, the clerk calls the guards/receiver and requests handover; refusing shifts to a supervised negotiation, surveillance or attempted recovery, not unrestricted browsing. Surrender is a player choice, not a compulsory entrance fee.

B Wagon yard: empty wagons, drums and six shields are being issued together. A dispatch copy provides clue A. The clerk wants loads counted and interruptions ended.

C Workers quarters: an unnamed survey assistant wants safe passage home. They helped measure the mill approach and now regret it. Practical concern earns clue B; threats get guarded answers, not deleted information.

D Survey and records tent: Sev spots a large, carefully annotated regional map. A bored records keeper permits supervised contractor inspection; copying, bargaining, distraction or theft are other routes. This is not Frulam’s personal tent.

E Signal and stores yard: shuttered lanterns and covered tools. An issue slip supplies clue C. The equipment keeper fears blame for missing stock and will trade information for a credible receipt.

F Watch post: two guards, an alarm bell and a view of the main entrance. They question suspicious activity; they do not magically know who stole a paper.

Three approaches with distinct strengths

Courier cover uses A and B, with access to D through paperwork. Worker cover uses C and earns a guide toward D or E. A stealth approach uses canvas gaps and the western laundry path. Describe sightlines, moving workers and the bell before players take risks. The camp is not one Stealth check. Choose the plate's concealment or secure custody before entry, and track who actually knows about it.

Suspicion follows observable actions

Visible plate response: an informed raider seeks to obtain it through payment, demand, escort to a receiver, watched exits or a feasible seizure. Outnumbered personnel can fetch help or shadow the party rather than attack suicidally. Warn of that response and give the players room to bargain, conceal, escape or fight. No offscreen confiscation; do not let a bored clerk ignore the wanted object. A guard who sees only a wrapped bundle does not automatically know what it is.

Track 0-3: 0 normal business; 1 questions and an escort; 2 a specific area searched; 3 alarm and exits watched. Advance only for a witnessed intrusion, exposed lie, found theft or violence. Clever explanations can contain suspicion. One failed check creates a complication, not universal recognition.

For uncertain improvised actions, use DC 11 for plausible low-risk work and DC 13 for a watched restricted area. Reward good plans with access or advantage. Talk openly about likely consequences. Current party resources determine whether combat is sensible.

The dragon passes overhead

Conversation thins as the animals pull at their tethers. A vast winged shadow crosses the camp. Faces turn upward. The dragon continues north without landing or speaking. Somewhere, a dropped ladle strikes a pot. Heads turn briefly away from their work.

Use once during camp exploration, not to erase an existing alarm. Give a brief opportunity to reposition or inspect something; do not grant automatic theft. If the plate is with the party, its carrier may feel one brief vibration through the wrapping. Pair that ambiguous reaction with the flyover and the northbound delivery evidence; this invites a possible connection, not proof of ownership, motive or identity. No NPC explains that "the dragon wants the plate." If the plate is absent, omit the vibration. Pat's scale need not react. Do not substitute a road flyover just because the party declines camp investigation.

If a fight happens

Start with the two local watch guards using S16 Hired Raider. Their purpose is to block a route or ring the bell. Show that the wider camp is dangerous before an assault. Escape, bargaining and surrender remain available. A clean infiltration is allowed to stay clean.

Arc 3 Solve the council map

Recover evidence • Hand the map to Sev • Let everyone work on it

The find

Under a stack of payment sheets is a survey of Greenest and its northern approaches. Sev, its notes record where wagons fit, where feet can pass, and which heights command a view. Three symbols repeat: a wheel, a spade and a lantern. Someone has planned movements around the town. The map is useful. The loose papers will tell you what it means.

The regional map is available at D. Reveal A, B and C as the party earns them at B, C and E. Backup copies: D has the dispatch and survey notes; the signal order travels with the messenger. A friendly witness can repeat observed details. Never require a particular theft, living NPC or skill roll for the only copy.

Ask three concrete questions

Which route does each marked group have to use? Place Wheel, Spade and Lantern on the map.

What is the loud movement intended to make the town do? Which group has the real local objective?

What event releases the hidden movement? What could the town change to break that coordination?

DM solution

Wheel = wagon road through the chalk cut. Its empty wagons, shields and drums create a conspicuous threat at the north approach. Lantern = signal ridge; only that site sees both the north approach and the east track. Spade = east drainage track, on foot, to reach the mill service lane after defenders are drawn north, enter the shallow space below, and break through masonry beside the sealed arch to retrieve what lies beyond. They are bypassing the failed lock with tools; they neither need the plate nor aim to destroy the mill/mechanism.

Sequence: Wheel makes noise at dusk; Lantern waits until town defenders move north; one long shuttered flash releases Spade. If the defenders stay home, there is no authorized flash. Spade is instructed to hold rather than begin a suicidal attack. This exposes a coordinated feint, not a guaranteed future victory.

Why the puzzle is fair

The map supplies terrain constraints; A supplies the deceptive load; B supplies the physical destination; C supplies the dependency. No cipher vocabulary, unseen lore or check is required. Wrong ideas can be tested against visible evidence. Once they explain routes, purpose and trigger, they have solved it. Do not require DM wording.

Hints, in order: “Could those wagons use that path?” Then “Why send empty wagons with drums?” Finally “Who is supposed to move before the lantern flashes?” A skill check can point to a missed sentence; it cannot replace their strategic choices.

Evidence and trust

Preserve or copy the orders and the map. The survey assistant can corroborate tool marks and routes but is neither compulsory nor automatically innocent. Floyd can distinguish a plausible engineering approach from a claimed magical shortcut. This drainage route reaches the mill exterior. The survey note then specifies bracing and a masonry breach beside the arch. Floyd can recognize this as a plausible but hazardous approach using the already seen structure, without discovering a giant hidden machine or knowing what lies beyond. The arch itself remains sealed until actual play changes it. The plate’s continuing transfer is a separate line of business.

Choose how to leave with what they learned

The party decides whether to slip out, leave under its cover, escort the witness, bargain with Mara or attempt disruption now. Do not impose a second extraction climax. Resolve immediate actions they choose; record changes to enemy awareness and resources for the later council.

Player evidence text and release gates

These exact texts generate the clue-card Word/PDF files. Reveal only the individual paper earned in play; the full packet is not an opening handout. All are unplayed prep, not already held by the party.

Payment slip at the chalk cut

40 gp on confirmed receipt. Plate intact. No channel test. F.M. Transfer north. Hold for L.

The existing illustrated payment slip remains correct. F.M. and L. are unresolved initials for the PCs, not an identification puzzle requiring lore. “No channel test” instructs couriers handling the recovered item; it does not mean the original

team never tried to open the arch. The Session 16 work order remains verbatim: “Under the mill. Brass plate intact. Do not turn the channels. North road, then the chalk cut. Deliver before dawn.”

Road dispatch at the chalk cut

Return tools to the northern camp by midday. The mill crew failed to open the old arch. New work at Greenest begins at dusk. Delivery of the intact plate continues north separately. Report to the survey desk for the approach and signal orders.

Mara has the dispatch and a practical route sketch; Doss can repeat its hauling instructions. Watching the cart crew consult it, bargaining, questioning or recovering their papers supplies it. If these people are missed, a dropped dispatch copy at the packing site preserves the lead after a meaningful search. This is a planned backup, not another object already found in Session 16. It supplies a reason to investigate before the camp is offered.

A Dispatch tally at the wagon yard

WHEEL - Two wagons; sacks filled with straw, not grain. Six shields. Two drums. No ladders, ram or provisions for an occupation. Arrive where the town can see you at dusk. Make yourselves heard. Await further orders before entering.

B Survey note with the survey assistant

SPADE - Eight pairs of boots. Picks, pry bars, rope and timber braces. Follow the low water route on foot; no wagons. Reach the mill work entrance, then the shallow space beneath. The old arch did not open. Brace the work and break through the masonry beside the sealed arch; recover what lies beyond. Do not waste time on the damaged lock or await the plate. Keep the mill and old channels standing. Move only on one long shuttered flash; otherwise hold.

C Signal instruction at the stores yard

LANTERN - Two observers. Your station must see both WHEEL and the low approach. After the drums begin, watch the town defenders. One long shuttered flash only when they move north. If they remain in position, hold the flash and send a runner. No independent advance.

The records tent keeps backup copies of A and B; the messenger carries a copy of C. Workers can corroborate what they actually saw. The map plus A/B/C establishes routes, purpose and trigger without any mandatory roll or named-villain knowledge.

Arc 4 Give the orders

Play the return or messenger contact • End with a committed plan

An earned invitation

There is no Greenest murder warrant or automatic arrest. Kai’s execution was the final Luskan bounty hunter on Stormwreck in Session 12. Confirmed Session 16 threats against the tavern guide may make leaders wary if reported; the mill rescue also counts. Do not assume town leaders know private events. The possible housekeeper threat is unconfirmed and cannot be presented as history. If the guide’s complaint reaches them, Nighthill can say, “I have heard a complaint about threats at the tavern. I will hear your warning. Show me the evidence.” Otherwise use a neutral request for corroboration.

Offer a return to Greenest with evidence; narrate the chosen journey only after players choose it. They can instead send a messenger and request a field meeting. If they refuse civic involvement, let them plan their own operation without granting authority they declined. Leave enough daylight for the return and discussion; dusk is a disclosed planning deadline, not a surprise punishment for roleplay.

When the party presents evidence, Nighthill asks, “Which parts did you witness, which are written orders, and which are your conclusions?” Let them show the dispatch, A/B/C, the copied map and any willing witness. If they can explain the diversion, observation trigger and physical breach, Escobert checks the routes. Only then offer: “You have shown us where they mean to put us. Now show us where we should stand. Escobert, tell them what we can actually spare.” With

incomplete evidence, offer corroborating reconnaissance or limited precautions; do not dismiss an imminent warning because the party is disliked.

Resources for the council exercise

Proposed available resources: three small guard teams; two volunteer work crews; one transport team with two carts. These are the forces available for reassignment, not every guard or civilian in Greenest. Background keep and sanctuary care continue. Confirm these prep quantities at the table before debate; do not silently change them afterward.

Each team gets one primary assignment for the opening phase. A later move is possible only with a route, timing and trigger. Volunteers can dig, brace, carry, guide or signal; they are not interchangeable with trained fighters. Patient movement needs care, escorts and a destination. The party chooses its own position and who keeps the plate.

Debate with concrete stakes

North approach: show a screen, stage a false withdrawal, negotiate, or hold strength back? A large visible response may trigger the enemy plan.

Mill lane and drainage track: quietly block, observe, ambush, patrol or concede? Protect access beneath the mill and the masonry beside the sealed arch; hiding the plate alone does not stop Spade. A barrier costs work and may be discovered; preserve an inspection and escape route.

Signal ridge: watch, seize, spoof or ignore it? Interference breaks coordination but can alert the camp. Do not promise it ends the wider conflict.

Keep, temple and west orchard: where do patients, workers and reserves go? Sheltering in place, limited relocation and organized evacuation are all legitimate.

Two workable examples for the DM only

Hold and expose: one guard team screens north; one protects the mill; one stays mobile. A work crew prepares a discreet barrier; the other supports shelter and signals. Carts remain for casualties. Defenders avoid the bait and challenge the exposed raiders.

Protect and intercept: two teams cover the mill route; one escorts a limited civilian relocation. Crews prepare refuge and observation; carts carry those unable to walk. The party watches the ridge or negotiates. This sacrifices some visible road control for people and the actual objective.

Neither is the answer key. Assess novel plans on the same known constraints. A credible explanation and viable assignments earn advisory authority for this operation; no Persuasion roll is needed to make competence count. Lasting leadership depends on outcomes and consent, not an automatic title.

Stop after the decision

Escobert places markers where you have ordered them. "Then these are our positions. What is the signal to act-and what tells us to fall back?"

Fill the decision record. End as orders are confirmed or messengers depart. Do not narrate the operation's result, an evacuation or the enemy's response before the players have chosen and we have storyboarded the consequences.

Session ending decision record

Fill from actual play • Blank fields remain unknown

What they know and possess

Map obtained or copied: _____ Clues A / B / C: _____

Witnesses and promises: _____

Plate holder and location: _____

Camp suspicion and evidence enemy has about the party: _____

What the party orders

Primary objective and acceptable cost: _____

Guard team 1 position / task: _____

Guard team 2 position / task: _____

Guard team 3 position / task: _____

Work crew 1 and 2: _____

Two carts / escorts / care / destination: _____

Party position and any split: _____

Signal / timing / who may give it: _____

Fallback trigger and route: _____

Orders kept secret / enemy deception / negotiation terms: _____

After play storyboard with Scott

Use the annotated map and actual orders to build 4-6 opening beats. For each: location; friendly intent; what opponents actually know; enemy response; warning the players can perceive; immediate choice; unresolved roll or uncertainty. Distinguish a prediction from a settled event.

First frame: show a visible consequence of one real player decision—a guarded lane, prepared refuge or occupied ridge.

Second frame: show the enemy move supported by its orders and current knowledge. Do not give opponents knowledge of a secret plan for dramatic convenience.

Third frame: let the two plans meet. Competent preparation should change position, timing or available choices.

Fourth frame: introduce a complication grounded in an accepted risk, not a random reversal designed to cancel success.

Final frame: return control at the first unresolved decision or contested action. Resolve danger in play; do not pre-decide casualties, betrayal or victory between sessions.

Record before leaving the table

Current HP, spent resources, secured rests, witnesses, promises, payments and exact enemy contact. Photograph or save the marked map. Quote the final orders back to the players and resolve contradictory instructions now.

No report of play is saved to canon without Scott's explicit save instruction. Unused scenes remain preparation.

Roll20 placement record from before this text revision

The following preserves the earlier September 29 setup verification. It is not a new check of live Roll20 after this rebuild; replace any separately uploaded old guide/clue text before use.

Roll20 final camp check - September 29, 2026

S17 04 - Northern Camp now has seven named NPC tokens on the Tokens layer:

Location	Token	Existing sheet	HP
A Delivery entrance	Delivery Clerk	Commoner	4/4
B Wagon yard	Wagon Clerk	Commoner	4/4
C Workers quarters	Survey Assistant	Commoner	4/4
D Survey and records tent	Records Keeper	Commoner	4/4
E Signal and stores yard	Equipment Keeper	Commoner	4/4
F Watch post	Camp Watch 1	S16 Hired Raider	9/9
F Watch post	Camp Watch 2	S16 Hired Raider	9/9

All seven have independent HP (bar link None) and visible nameplates. Watch guards use AC 12 and the existing S16 Hired Raider sheet, not a duplicated replacement. Clerks and workers are noncombatants unless play establishes otherwise. The map is populated for interaction or combat; there are no automatic surprise reinforcements. GM canvas placement was visually verified. This final pass did not repeat the earlier player-view test.

Final camp screenshot